

Datacentres hyperscale capex growth

#australia

#construction

By [Pat Bustamante](#) & [Luka Belobrajdic](#)

16:15 May 28 2026

 Share

Private capex surprised on the upside, rising 6.5%qtr and 14.6%yr in the March quarter 2026. Machinery and equipment led the jump, driven by a 196%qtr surge in information and telecommunications, while buildings and structures were weaker.



Private capex surprised on the upside, rising 6.5%qtr and 14.6%yr in the March quarter 2026, the largest quarterly increase since the height of the mining boom in 2012. Despite our view that data centres would lead a strong result in the quarter, today's outcome exceeded even our top of the range

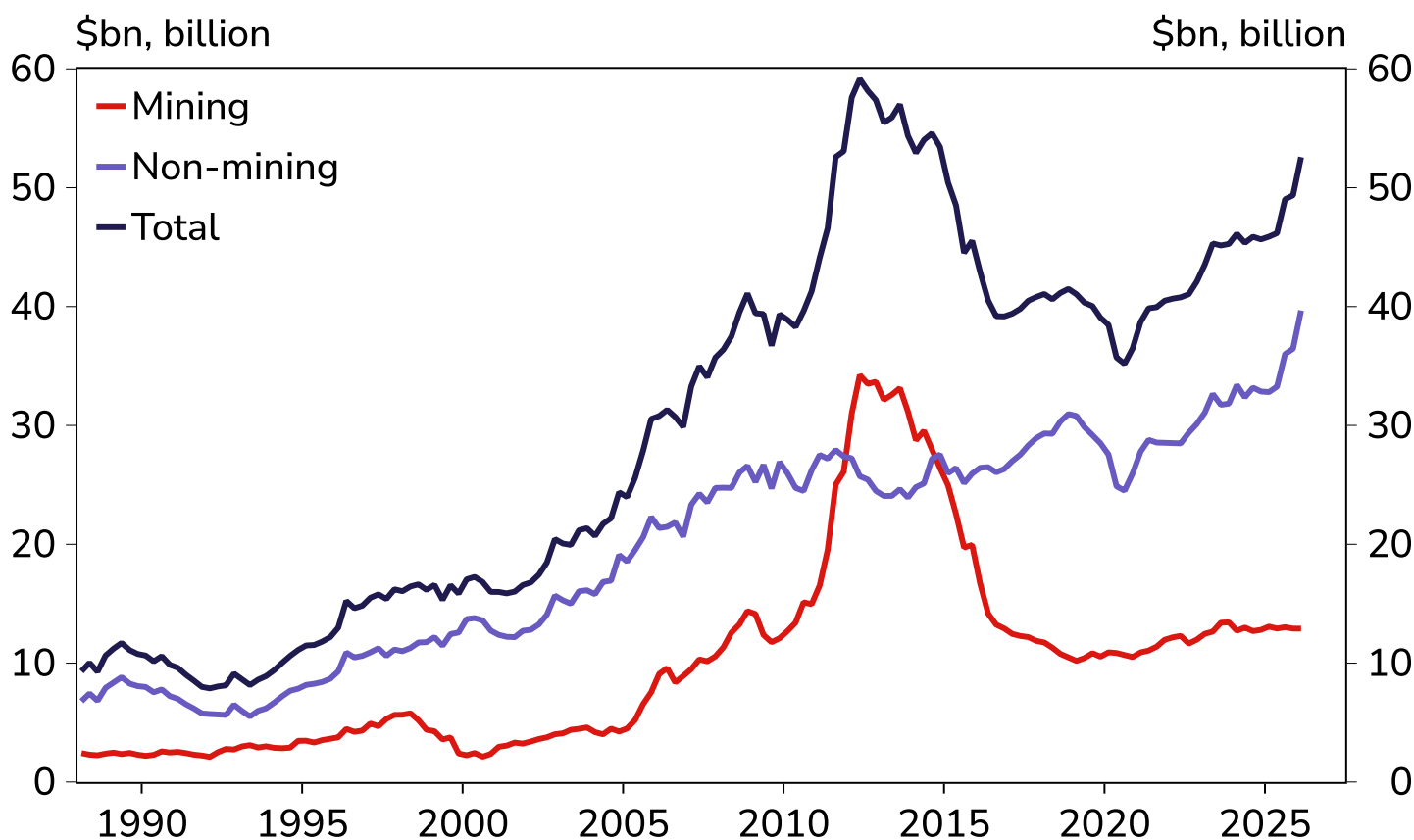
expectation for a 4.0%qtr rise, with market consensus far more subdued at 1.0%qtr.

The sharp increase was driven by machinery and equipment, which rose 18%qtr. This was the strongest quarterly growth since the December quarter 1992 – even stronger than what we saw during the mining investment boom of the 2000s. It was led by a 196%qtr surge in information and telecommunications. Excluding this industry, M&E rose a more modest 1.2%qtr. By contrast, buildings and structures were a drag on the headline, falling 3.8%qtr, with data-centre construction providing some offset.

Looking ahead, capex plans suggest some moderation in the June quarter but still point to strong outcomes for FY2026. In real terms, this implies growth of around 10.7%yr for the full year. The second estimate for FY2027 also points to a further step-up in investment.

Capital Expenditure

By industry



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

What does this mean for next week's National Accounts?

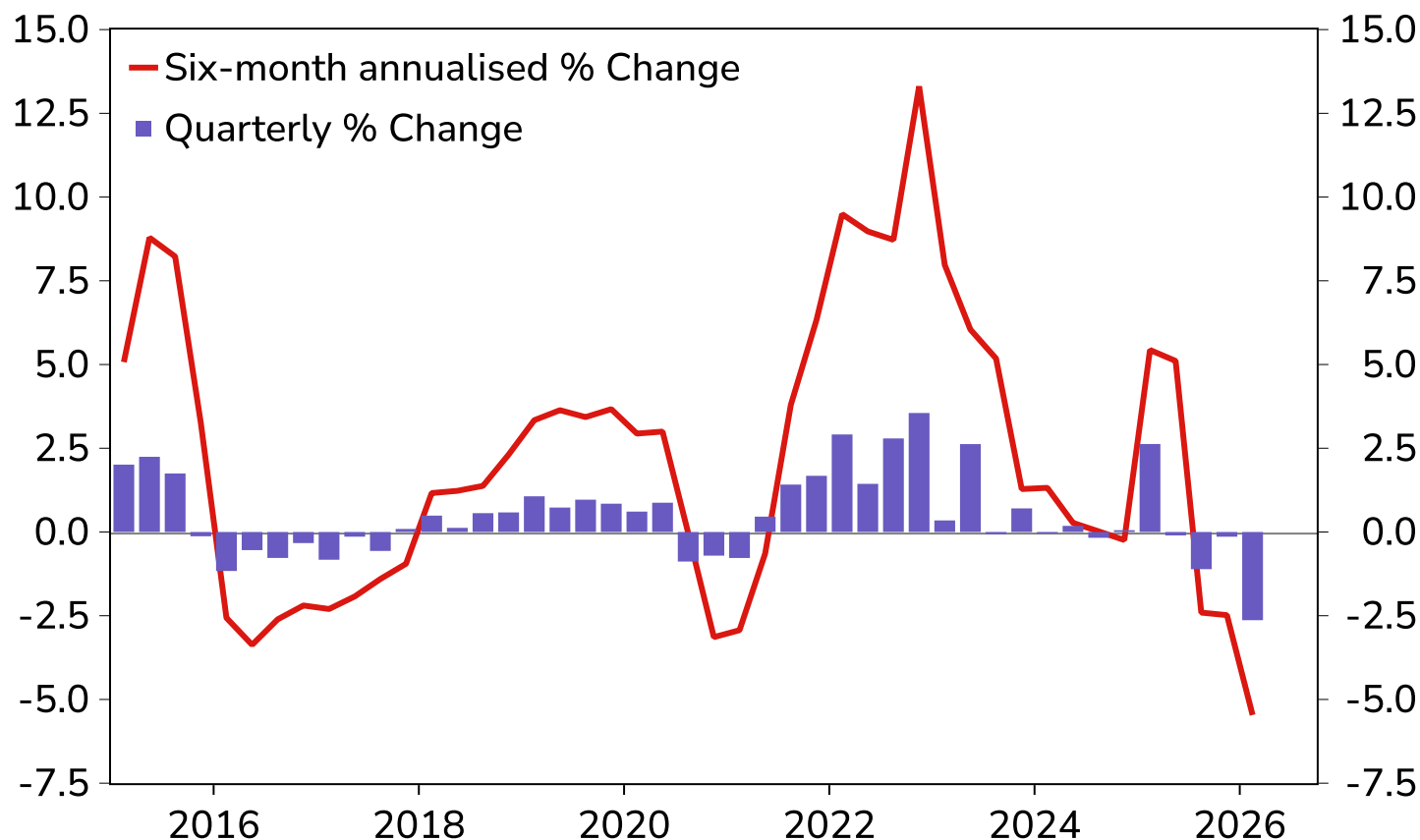
Capex data today, alongside yesterday's construction work done release, point to a modest upside risk to our Q1 2026 GDP nowcast (full update tomorrow). However, the stronger capex pulse should translate only partially into GDP, with a significant share leaking abroad. Trade data collaborates this with capital imports increasing around 7.0%qtr in Q1 (and almost 8.0%qtr when aircrafts are excluded).

What about inflationary pressures?

Capex price pressures have eased materially. The machinery deflator has declined for a fourth consecutive quarter, marking a full year of retreat, with a 5.5% fall in six-month annualised terms. This likely reflects the import-intensive nature of data-centre investment—evidenced by a 94%qtr rise in ADP equipment imports—alongside an appreciation in the Australian dollar during Q1 2026. This disinflationary impulse should help contain cost pressures for businesses and support ongoing investment.

New Machinery and Equipment Price Index

Seasonally Adjusted



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Industry detail

Mining capex was broadly flat in the quarter, with a 7.2% rise in machinery and equipment offset by a 2.9% decline in buildings and structures. Non-mining capex rose strongly, increasing 8.8%qtr and 20.9%yr—the largest year-ended increase since Q3 2005. This was driven by a 20.1%qtr rise in machinery and equipment, while buildings and structures declined 4.3%qtr.

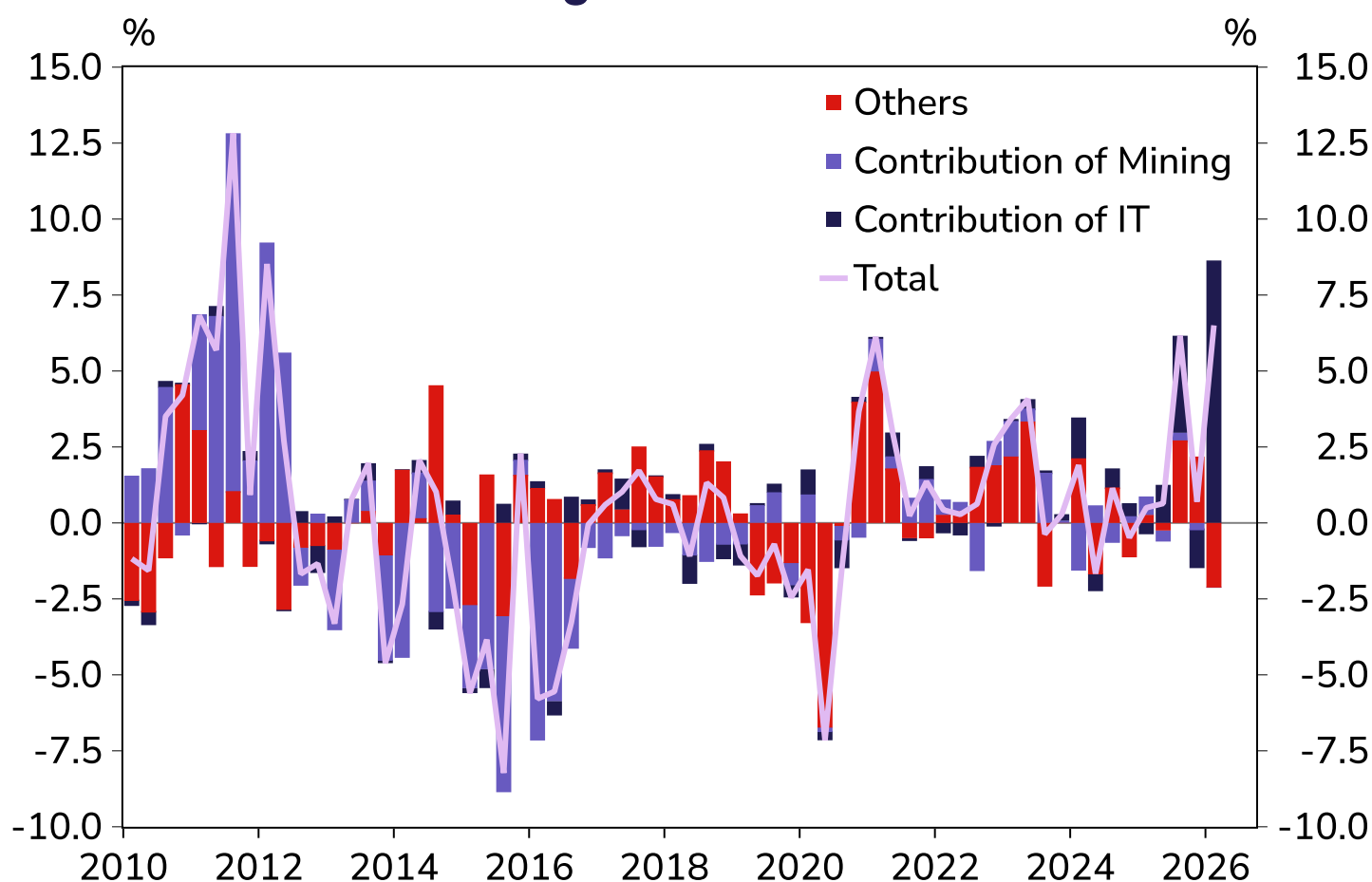
As we were expecting, information and telecommunications was the clear standout, rising 96.1%qtr. Leading indicators—particularly strong ADP equipment imports and commercial building approvals—had pointed to a large increase. This outcome is the strongest since March 2007 and cements the sector as the second largest by capex (\$8.7bn), behind mining (\$12.9bn). While buildings and structures rose 12.6%qtr, the surge was overwhelmingly driven by machinery and equipment, which

rose 196%qtr, leaving M&E more than double the value of buildings and structures investment. The scale-up in data-centre investment is increasingly reminiscent of the early-2010s mining boom, with the sector contributing more to overall capex growth than all other industries combined. While current investment is concentrated in import-intensive equipment—with relatively limited immediate domestic GDP impact—this is likely to shift as projects transition to the production phase.

Elsewhere, retail trade recorded a strong 12.2%qtr increase, with buildings and structures up 17.8%qtr and machinery and equipment rising 9.8%qtr. This marks a second consecutive quarterly rise, pointing to a lift alongside the cyclical upswing we saw in 2025, although the sustainability of this momentum remains uncertain given weak consumer sentiment.

Electricity, gas, water and waste declined 8.4%qtr, following a 12%qtr rise previously, with the ABS noting a series of large projects reached completion over the quarter. Both buildings and structures (-8.5%qtr) and machinery and equipment (-7.0%qtr) contributed to the decline. Despite this, the sector is expected to be supported over coming quarters by the energy transition and increased infrastructure demand linked to data-centre expansion.

Contributions to CAPEX growth



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Capex spending plans

Alongside the capex data, the ABS also publishes businesses spending plans for this financial year, which allows us to assess how the capex spending is likely to evolve over the coming quarters. Usually,

those plans tend to have a bias, with companies first estimates usually erring on the side of caution. Over time, business tend to revise their plans higher. We apply a methodology, that takes historical ratios of plans to actuals alongside business conditions which allows us to derive a more realistic capex estimate in the year ahead.

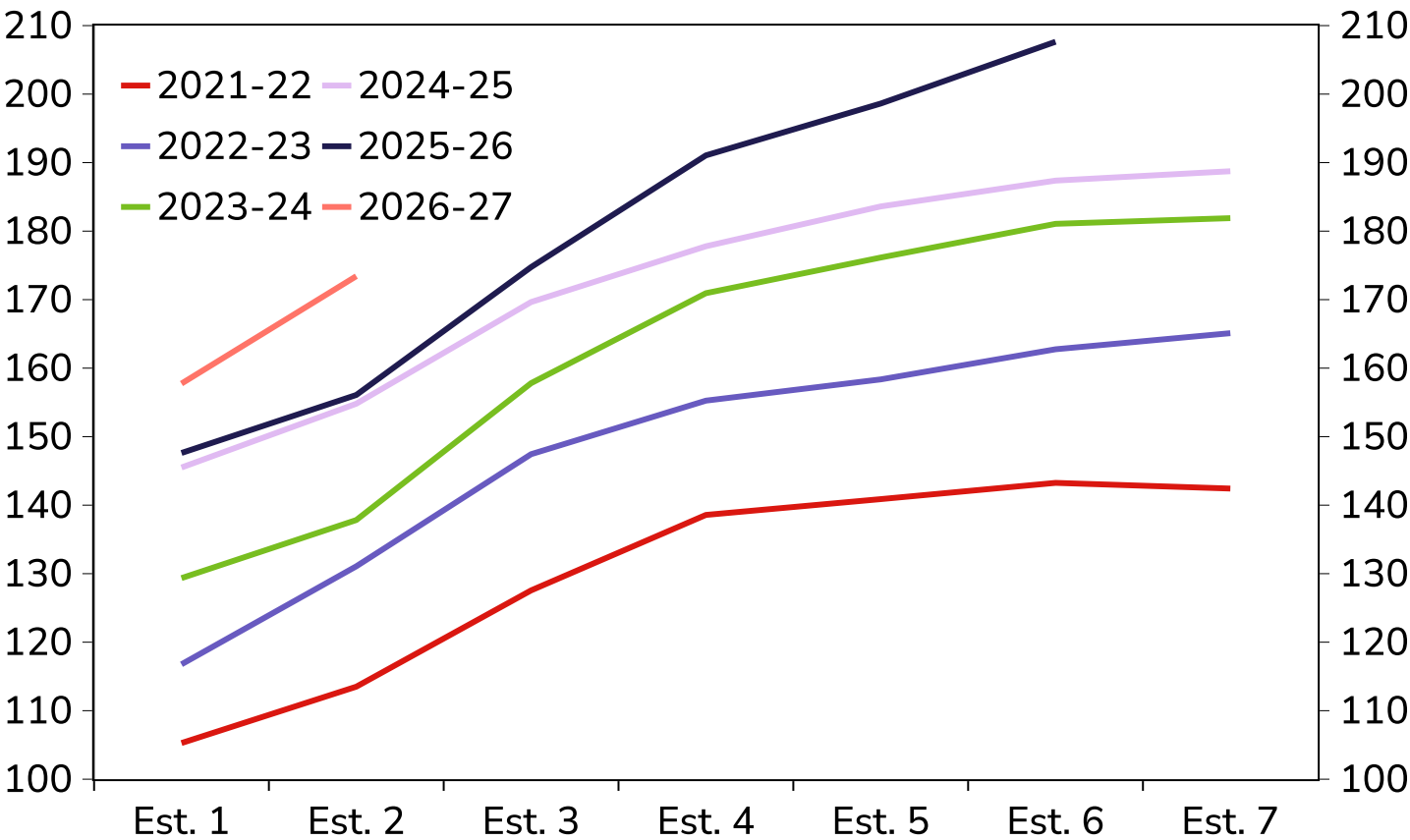
Estimate 6 for FY2026 came in at \$208bn, above our expectation of \$204bn, and pointing to continued resilience despite weaker business confidence. This represents an 11.2% increase on a year ago and a 4.5% upward revision from Estimate 5. Based on the historical profile of estimates, this implies nominal capex of around \$210bn for FY2026, an 11.2%yr increase.

Estimate 2 for FY2027 came in at \$173bn, an 11% increase over the equivalent estimate a year ago. This result is a clear step-up from 0.8% growth of the equivalent estimate for FY26, and suggests firms expect investment momentum to be sustained.

Price effects are playing a diminishing role. The capex deflator fell 0.7%yr, signalling a marked easing in inflationary pressures. This reflects strong imports of ADP equipment alongside the appreciation in the Australian dollar in Q1 2026, which has weighed on machinery and equipment prices. We expect the deflator to remain soft through the remainder of the financial year, with full-year average growth of 0.5%yr. Combined with nominal growth of 11.2%yr, this implies real capex growth of around 10.7%yr – the strongest result since FY2012, and a notable upward revision from our previous expectation of 7.1%.

Capex Spending Plans

Value, \$bn



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Stay informed with Westpac IQ

Get the latest reports straight to your inbox.

Subscribe

Related articles



#australia

Hours worked reveals a deeper story about labour supply

May 28 2026 • ⌚ 5 mins

By Ryan Wells



#australia

Mining masks weakening construction, sharpening the RBA trade-off

May 27 2026 • ⌚ 5 mins

By Pat Bustamante



[#australia](#)

Australia and NZ Weekly 25 May 2026

May 25 2026 • ⌚ 10 mins

By [Luci Ellis](#), [Matthew Hassan](#), [Elliot Clarke](#) & [9 more](#)

Browse topics

[#aud](#)

[#australia](#)

[#interestrates](#)

[#nzd](#)

[#usd](#)

[#newzealand](#)

[#rates](#)

[#credit](#)

[#yieldcurve](#)

[#acgb](#)

[#inflation](#)

[#rba](#)

[#semigovernment](#)

[#basis](#)

[#commodities](#)

[#ustreasury](#)

[#fx](#)

[#rbnz](#)

[#jpy](#)

[#abs](#)

[Show more tags](#)

Disclaimer

©2026 Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 (including where acting under any of its Westpac, St George, Bank of Melbourne or BankSA brands, collectively, “Westpac”). References to the “Westpac Group” are to Westpac and its subsidiaries and includes the directors, employees and representatives of Westpac and its subsidiaries.

Things you should know

We respect your privacy: You can view the [New Zealand Privacy Policy](#) here, or the [Australian Group Privacy Statement](#) here. Each time someone visits our site, data is captured so that we can accurately evaluate the quality of our content and make improvements for you. We may at times use technology to capture data about you to help us to better understand you and your needs, including potentially for the purposes of assessing your individual reading habits and interests to allow us to provide suggestions regarding other reading material which may be suitable for you.

This information, unless specifically indicated otherwise, is under copyright of the Westpac Group. None of the material, nor its contents, nor any copy of it, may be altered in any way, transmitted to, copied or distributed to any other party without the prior written permission of the Westpac Group.

Disclaimer

This information has been prepared by Westpac and is intended for information purposes only. It is not intended to reflect any recommendation or financial advice and investment decisions should not be based on it. This information does not constitute an offer, a solicitation of an offer, or an inducement to subscribe for, purchase or sell any financial instrument or to enter into a legally binding contract. To the extent that this information contains any general advice, it has been prepared without taking into account your objectives, financial situation or needs and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the advice. Certain types of transactions, including those involving futures, options and high yield securities give rise to substantial risk and are not suitable for all investors. We recommend that you seek your own independent legal or financial advice before proceeding with any investment decision.

This information may contain material provided by third parties. While such material is published with the necessary permission none of Westpac or its related entities accepts any responsibility for the accuracy or completeness of any such material. Although we have made every effort to ensure this information is free from error, none of Westpac or its related entities warrants the accuracy, adequacy or completeness of this information, or otherwise endorses it in any way. Except where contrary to law, Westpac Group intend by this notice to exclude liability for this information. This information is subject to change without notice and none of Westpac or its related entities is under any obligation to update this information or correct any inaccuracy which may become apparent at a later date. This information may contain or incorporate by reference forward-looking statements. The words “believe”, “anticipate”, “expect”, “intend”, “plan”, “predict”, “continue”, “assume”, “positioned”, “may”, “will”, “should”, “shall”, “risk” and other similar expressions that are predictions of or indicate future events and future trends identify forward-looking statements. These forward-

looking statements include all matters that are not historical facts. Past performance is not a reliable indicator of future performance, nor are forecasts of future performance. Whilst every effort has been taken to ensure that the assumptions on which any forecasts are based are reasonable, the forecasts may be affected by incorrect assumptions or by known or unknown risks and uncertainties. The ultimate outcomes may differ substantially from any forecasts.

Conflicts of Interest: In the normal course of offering banking products and services to its clients, the Westpac Group may act in several capacities (including issuer, market maker, underwriter, distributor, swap counterparty and calculation agent) simultaneously with respect to a financial instrument, giving rise to potential conflicts of interest which may impact the performance of a financial instrument. The Westpac Group may at any time transact or hold a position (including hedging and trading positions) for its own account or the account of a client in any financial instrument which may impact the performance of that financial instrument.

Author(s) disclaimer and declaration: The author(s) confirms that (a) no part of his/her compensation was, is, or will be, directly or indirectly, related to any views or (if applicable) recommendations expressed in this material; (b) this material accurately reflects his/her personal views about the financial products, companies or issuers (if applicable) and is based on sources reasonably believed to be reliable and accurate; (c) to the best of the author's knowledge, they are not in receipt of inside information and this material does not contain inside information; and (d) no other part of the Westpac Group has made any attempt to influence this material.

Further important information regarding sustainability-related content: This material may contain statements relating to environmental, social and governance (ESG) topics. These are subject to known and unknown risks, and there are significant uncertainties, limitations, risks and assumptions in the metrics, modelling, data, scenarios, reporting and analysis on which the statements rely. In particular, these areas are rapidly evolving and maturing, and there are variations in approaches and common standards and practice, as well as uncertainty around future related policy and legislation. Some material may include information derived from publicly available sources that have not been independently verified. No representation or warranty is made as to the accuracy, completeness or reliability of the information. There is a risk that the analysis, estimates, judgements, assumptions, views, models, scenarios or projections used may turn out to be incorrect. These risks may cause actual outcomes to differ materially from those expressed or implied. The ESG-related statements in this material do not constitute advice, nor are they guarantees or predictions of future performance, and Westpac gives no representation, warranty or assurance (including as to the quality, accuracy or completeness of the statements). You should seek your own independent advice.

Additional country disclosures:

Australia: Westpac holds an Australian Financial Services Licence (No. 233714). You can access Westpac's Financial Services Guide [here](#) or request a copy from your Westpac point of contact. To the extent that this information contains any general advice, it has been prepared without taking into account your objectives, financial situation or needs and before acting on it you should consider the

appropriateness of the advice.

New Zealand: In New Zealand, Westpac Institutional Bank refers to the brand under which products and services are provided by either Westpac (NZ division) or Westpac New Zealand Limited (company number 1763882), the New Zealand incorporated subsidiary of Westpac ("WNZL"). Any product or service made available by WNZL does not represent an offer from Westpac or any of its subsidiaries (other than WNZL). Neither Westpac nor its other subsidiaries guarantee or otherwise support the performance of WNZL in respect of any such product. WNZL is not an authorised deposit-taking institution for the purposes of Australian prudential standards. The current disclosure statements for the New Zealand branch of Westpac and WNZL can be obtained at the internet address www.westpac.co.nz.

Singapore: This material has been prepared and issued for distribution in Singapore to institutional investors, accredited investors and expert investors (as defined in the applicable Singapore laws and regulations) only. Recipients of this material in Singapore should contact Westpac Singapore Branch in respect of any matters arising from, or in connection with, this material. Westpac Singapore Branch holds a wholesale banking licence and is subject to supervision by the Monetary Authority of Singapore.

Fiji: Unless otherwise specified, the products and services for Westpac Fiji are available from www.westpac.com.fj © Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141. This information does not take your personal circumstances into account and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the information for your financial situation. Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 is incorporated in NSW Australia and registered as a branch in Fiji. The liability of its members is limited.

Papua New Guinea: Unless otherwise specified, the products and services for Westpac PNG are available from www.westpac.com.pg © Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141. This information does not take your personal circumstances into account and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the information for your financial situation. Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 is incorporated in NSW Australia. Westpac is represented in Papua New Guinea by Westpac Bank - PNG - Limited. The liability of its members is limited.

U.S.: Westpac operates in the United States of America as a federally licensed branch, regulated by the Office of the Comptroller of the Currency. Westpac is also registered with the US Commodity Futures Trading Commission ("CFTC") as a Swap Dealer, but is neither registered as, or affiliated with, a Futures Commission Merchant registered with the US CFTC. The services and products referenced above are not insured by the Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation ("FDIC"). Westpac Capital Markets, LLC ('WCM'), a wholly-owned subsidiary of Westpac, is a broker-dealer registered under the U.S. Securities Exchange Act of 1934 ('the Exchange Act') and member of the Financial Industry Regulatory Authority ('FINRA'). In accordance with APRA's Prudential Standard 222 'Association with Related Entities', Westpac does not stand behind WCM other than as provided for in certain legal agreements between Westpac and WCM and obligations of WCM do not represent

liabilities of Westpac.

This communication is provided for distribution to U.S. institutional investors in reliance on the exemption from registration provided by Rule 15a-6 under the Exchange Act and is not subject to all of the independence and disclosure standards applicable to debt research reports prepared for retail investors in the United States. WCM is the U.S. distributor of this communication and accepts responsibility for the contents of this communication. Transactions by U.S. customers of any securities referenced herein should be effected through WCM. All disclaimers set out with respect to Westpac apply equally to WCM. If you would like to speak to someone regarding any security mentioned herein, please contact WCM on +1 212 389 1269. Investing in any non-U.S. securities or related financial instruments mentioned in this communication may present certain risks. The securities of non-U.S. issuers may not be registered with, or be subject to the regulations of, the SEC in the United States. Information on such non-U.S. securities or related financial instruments may be limited. Non-U.S. companies may not be subject to audit and reporting standards and regulatory requirements comparable to those in effect in the United States. The value of any investment or income from any securities or related derivative instruments denominated in a currency other than U.S. dollars is subject to exchange rate fluctuations that may have a positive or adverse effect on the value of or income from such securities or related derivative instruments.

The author of this communication is employed by Westpac and is not registered or qualified as a research analyst, representative, or associated person of WCM or any other U.S. broker-dealer under the rules of FINRA, any other U.S. self-regulatory organisation, or the laws, rules or regulations of any State. Unless otherwise specifically stated, the views expressed herein are solely those of the author and may differ from the information, views or analysis expressed by Westpac and/or its affiliates.

UK: The London branch of Westpac is authorised in the United Kingdom by the Prudential Regulation Authority (PRA) and is subject to regulation by the Financial Conduct Authority (FCA) and limited regulation by the PRA (Financial Services Register number: 124586). The London branch of Westpac is registered at Companies House as a branch established in the United Kingdom (Branch No. BR000106). Details about the extent of the regulation of Westpac's London branch by the PRA are available from us on request.

This communication is not being made to or distributed to, and must not be passed on to, the general public in the United Kingdom. Rather, this communication is being made only to and is directed at (a) those persons falling within the definition of Investment Professionals (set out in Article 19(5) of the Financial Services and Markets Act 2000 (Financial Promotion) Order 2005 (the "Order")); (b) those persons falling within the definition of high net worth companies, unincorporated associations etc. (set out in Article 49(2) of the Order; (c) other persons to whom it may lawfully be communicated in accordance with the Order or (d) any persons to whom it may otherwise lawfully be made (all such persons together being referred to as "relevant persons"). Any person who is not a relevant person should not act or rely on this communication or any of its contents. In the same way, the information contained in this communication is intended for "eligible counterparties" and

“professional clients” as defined by the rules of the Financial Conduct Authority and is not intended for “retail clients”. Westpac expressly prohibits you from passing on the information in this communication to any third party.

European Economic Area (“EEA”): This material may be distributed to you by either: (i) Westpac directly, or (ii) Westpac Europe GmbH (“WEG”) under a sub-licensing arrangement. WEG has not edited or otherwise modified the content of this material. WEG is authorised in Germany by the Federal Financial Supervision Authority (‘BaFin’) and subject to its regulation. WEG’s supervisory authorities are BaFin and the German Federal Bank (‘Deutsche Bundesbank’). WEG is registered with the commercial register (‘Handelsregister’) of the local court of Frankfurt am Main under registration number HRB 118483. In accordance with APRA’s Prudential Standard 222 ‘Association with Related Entities’, Westpac does not stand behind WEG other than as provided for in certain legal agreements (a risk transfer, sub-participation and collateral agreement) between Westpac and WEG and obligations of WEG do not represent liabilities of Westpac. Any product or service made available by WEG does not represent an offer from Westpac or any of its subsidiaries (other than WEG). All disclaimers set out with respect to Westpac apply equally to WEG.

This communication is not intended for distribution to, or use by any person or entity in any jurisdiction or country where such distribution or use would be contrary to local law or regulation.

This communication contains general commentary, research, and market colour. The communication does not constitute investment advice. The material may contain an ‘investment recommendation’ and/or ‘information recommending or suggesting an investment’, both as defined in Regulation (EU) No 596/2014 (including as applicable in the United Kingdom) (“MAR”). In accordance with the relevant provisions of MAR, reasonable care has been taken to ensure that the material has been objectively presented and that interests or conflicts of interest of the sender concerning the financial instruments to which that information relates have been disclosed.

Investment recommendations must be read alongside the specific disclosure which accompanies them and the general disclosure which can be found [here](#). Such disclosure fulfils certain additional information requirements of MAR and associated delegated legislation and by accepting this communication you acknowledge that you are aware of the existence of such additional disclosure and its contents.

To the extent this communication comprises an investment recommendation it is classified as non-independent research. It has not been prepared in accordance with legal requirements designed to promote the independence of investment research and therefore constitutes a marketing communication. Further, this communication is not subject to any prohibition on dealing ahead of the dissemination of investment research.